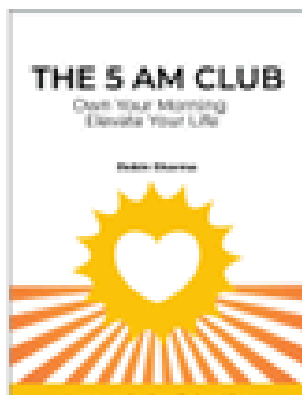




THE 5AM CLUB

Own your Morning. Elevate your Life.

ROBIN SHARMA



The Big "So What"

In this book, Robin Sharma invites you to join the 5AM Club and the ranks of the top 5% of performers. Using a parable, he explains various productivity principles and tactics built on research and brain sciences, to help you transform your results, health, and happiness.



The Parable



The parable is about 2 people who managed to transform their lives with the help of a guru and a tycoon.

- The story began with an Entrepreneur whose life was falling apart, and an Artist who wanted to unlock his creativity and potential. They met at a seminar by the Spellbinder, a famous guru known for his teachings on peak performance, neurobiology and human potential. At the seminar, the Entrepreneur and Artist ran into an eccentric multi-billionaire who'd been personally mentored by the Spellbinder. The Billionaire invited them to his private island, where he imparted the principles and insights that had transformed his life (and would now transform theirs).
- The 5 AM Club is the cornerstone of achieving world-class performance and living a splendid life. It involves the habit of waking up at 5am daily, starting your day on a right note, and adopting a range of positive habits to multiply your results.



Throughout the story, the Billionaire and Spellbinder share quotes from famous people, findings from scientific

KEY QUOTES

"Every professional was once an amateur, and every master started as a beginner. Ordinary people can accomplish extraordinary feats, once they've routinized the right habits."

research, frameworks, principles and tactics for achieving peak performance, inner peace and joy. We've distilled and organized the key insights into 2 parts in this summary:

- The ingredients for top performance; and
- How to become a member of the 5 AM Club.



Part 1: The Ingredients for Top Performance



The 3-Step Success Formula



To be in the top 5% and gain a “Gargantuan Competitive Advantage” (GCA), you must be willing to do what 95% of people don't or won't do. This starts with choosing how to lead your life.

- Leadership isn't about your title or position; it's about what you stand for, focus on and commit to on a daily basis.
- To become a master in any field, you need rigor and persistence. Masters spend years to learn, experiment and improve their expertise and insight. Every wildly-successful person has had his/her share of struggles. For example, Stephen King faced so many rejections that he actually threw away the manuscript for “Carrie” in frustration. Fortunately, his wife recovered the manuscript from the trash and this became King's first published novel.
- Masters also demand the highest standards down to the granular details. Instead of churning out hundreds of mediocre pieces, they spend years to perfect the details of a single masterpiece. F1 crews adopt fastidious standards in their checks, calibration and cleanliness because they know that a loose screw or a speck of dirt can mean the difference between winning and losing, or life and death. Indeed, the Challenger space shuttle exploded due to the failure of a single, seemingly-inconsequential O-ring seal.



In short, there're 3 steps to achieving phenomenal success:

KEY QUOTES

“Each of you has a call on your lives. Every one of you carries an instinct for excellence within your spirits.”

“Leadership is a lot less about having a formal title, a large office and money in the bank. And a lot more about committing to mastery over all you do—and in who you are.”

“Consistency is the key to mastery.”

“Geniuses understand that it's smarter to create one masterwork than one thousand ordinary pieces.”



- Be aware of your values, why you do what you do, and how you want to be remembered.
- Use this consciousness to guide your daily choices, so that every action you take contributes to your goal.
- Applied rigorously and consistently, the 3 steps will dramatically improve your results and impact.

The most outstanding people commit to becoming the best version of themselves and living an original life. They demand high standards in all aspects of their attitudes, actions, and output.



By contrast, 95% of people only achieve mediocre results because they lack the clarity, focus and discipline of the top performers.

- Most people follow the same mindless routine daily. They spend their time checking emails/messages, surfing the internet, watching TV and doing menial chores. They find excuses for not pushing themselves beyond their comfort zone. Instead of maximizing their potential or impact, they pursue bigger salaries, titles and houses to impress others.
- Geniuses are often treated like weirdos or misfits because of their crazy visions and maniacal standards. Ironically, these visions and standards are what make them top achievers in the first place.



To become a master of your life and craft, you must be willing to pay the price.

- Be prepared to persist in face of ridicule/criticism and stick to your vision and standards even when you don't feel like it.
- Realize that true power doesn't come from your riches or status, but your inner state—how far you tap into your talents, and live with self-discipline, integrity, honesty, and empathy. By all means enjoy the money and status

KEY QUOTES

"World-class is a process, not an event."

"The majority is stuck in vague, imprecise thinking. And vague, imprecise thinking yields vague, imprecise results."

"You can fit in. Or you can change the world. You don't get to do both."

that comes with success, but do so without becoming attached to them or allowing them to define who you are.



4 Areas of Focus for Top Performance

Top performers focus on four things: leveraging their talents, working without distractions, gaining personal mastery, and consistently stacking small wins. Sharma calls these the “four focuses of history makers.”



Top achievers aren't born with superior talent; they simply actualize more of their potential. “Capitalization IQ” is the ability to put your inborn gifts to use.

- To attain mastery or world-class standards, you need to work at something for a long period of time. This in turn requires the right beliefs and self-identity. If you don't believe you have what it takes, you won't persist long enough to succeed. Build your self-belief and confidence, then get to work on unleashing your inner giant and genius.



Free yourself from distractions. You can't deliver exceptional results if your mental capacity is diluted across too many things.

- One of the biggest sources of distractions comes from addiction to technology. If you spend the entire day on your devices, you'll find yourself overwhelmed by endless emails, messages and social media updates, leaving you with no time or energy for meaningful work.
- We also tend to self-sabotage. As part of our survival instinct, the “primitive” part of our brain (the limbic brain) is always looking for threats or danger. The prefrontal cortex (in charge of higher-level thinking) seeks growth and progress. When you're working on something challenging, you may suddenly feel the urge to jump on a new idea/opportunity, take a break, or work on something else. This is your primitive brain trying to distract you from the difficult task (due to its fear of failure and uncertainty). Be aware of this tendency, so you can resist the impulse and deliberate persist onward.

KEY QUOTES

“Stop managing your time and start managing your focus.”

“There's a staggering difference between being busy and being productive.”

- Don't confuse busyness with productivity. Simplify your life and concentrate on just a few high-value items at any point in time. Focus on a few projects that you can deliver with stellar results, instead of jumping from task to task. Invest your time and energy on a few deep, meaningful relationships instead of many shallow ones. Work on a 1 important activity at a time instead of multitasking.



Your external results are a reflection of your inner state (your mindset, creativity, abilities, confidence etc.). Continually improve your personal mastery and abilities to multiply your results.

- In particular, use the 5 AM Club to build 4 "interior empires":
 - (i) *Mindset* (psychology): Work on your deepest beliefs, self-talk and outlook, which jointly define how you think and act.
 - (ii) *Heartset* (emotionality): You can't produce amazing work if you're weighed down by resentment, sadness or fear. Improve your emotional health by releasing toxic emotions and opening your heart to gratitude and joy.
 - (iii) *Healthset* (physicality): Build your physical fitness to increase your energy levels, operate at an optimal cognitive state, and improve your longevity.
 - (iv) *Soulset* (spirituality): Spend some quiet time to remember who you truly are, connect with yourself and rediscover your compassion, conviction, and courage.



If you consistently improve by 1% a day, you'll minimally elevate yourself by 365% each year. Sharma calls this "day stacking." Focus on what you can do today to build an exceptional life. Live fully and unapologetically, dare to love and express yourself, and feel truly alive in the moment.

KEY QUOTES

"An intense concentration only on what matters most is how the pros realize victory. Simplify. Simplify. Simplify."

*"The only devils in the world are those running in our own hearts. That is where the battle should be fought."
- Mahatma Gandhi*

"Small, daily, seemingly insignificant improvements, when done consistently over time, yield staggering results."



Part 2: Joining the 5 AM Club

The 5 AM Club (waking up at 5am and using the 20/20/20 Formula below) gives you a headstart in cultivating the clarity, discipline, rigor, and habits for top performance.



How It Works

The 5 AM Club is built on various scientific truths about the brain, willpower and habits.



When we're awake, our prefrontal cortex is usually in a state of hyper-activity, analyzing and worrying about everything. When you wake up at 5am, the peace and quiet allows your prefrontal cortex to switch off temporarily so you enter a state of "transient hypofrontality".

- In this state, your brain waves slow down from beta to alpha (or even theta). The peace and silence also trigger the release of hormones like dopamine and serotonin, all of which put your brain in the ideal condition to enter a Flow state—a state of joyful peak performance where you're absorbed in a challenging task and operating at the edge of your abilities.
- Many famous people—including John Grisham, Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart, Georgia O'Keeffe, Frank Lloyd Wright and Ernest Hemingway—have the habit of waking before daybreak.



Neuroplasticity refers to our brain's ability to change throughout our lives. When we do something repeatedly, it causes certain neural circuits to fire together and eventually wire together, making the task easier to perform. After years of navigating the complex streets of London, the cabbies there were found to have a larger-than-usual hippocampus (which handles spatial reasoning). People who're constantly learning and challenging themselves will develop different brains from those who don't.



Willpower isn't an inborn trait. It's actually a skill that can be developed through practice, like how we build muscles.

KEY QUOTES

"Anyone can be great for a minute. The sport of icons is sustaining genius-grade performance over a lifetime."

"You don't have the brain you want, you have the brain you've earned."

- Increasing our self-control in 1 aspect of our life also increases self-control in other areas.
- However, willpower gets depleted with use and weakens when we're tired. That's why we find it harder to exert self-control or make good decisions at the end of a long day.
- Top producers outperform others because they've built the habit of performing high-value activities. Initially, they had to force themselves to persist each time they felt like quitting. Over time, they strengthen their willpower, self-mastery and discipline, until it's habitual to operate at a higher level.
- You can also build your willpower by regularly putting yourself in uncomfortable situations, e.g. sleeping on the floor once a week, taking cold morning showers, or fasting a few times a month.

 You need to exert willpower to build a new habit. However, once you've installed the habit, it becomes automatic and effortless. There are 4 steps involved in habits formation:

- The process begins with a trigger, e.g. an alarm ringing at 5am.
- Once that happens, it's important to establish the right ritual by jumping out of bed and moving into your Victory Hour (elaborated below). Going back to bed will only create an undesirable habit.
- Make sure you reward yourself each time you complete the desired ritual, e.g. treat yourself to some dark chocolate or an afternoon nap.
- Each time you repeat the cycle, you're rewiring your brain and locking in the new habit.



 It takes about 66 days to form a new habit over 3 phases.



KEY QUOTES

"To regularly do that which is hard but important when it feels most uncomfortable is how warriors are born."

"Legendary performers practice being spectacular for so long that they no longer remember how to behave in non-spectacular ways."

"The soreness of growth is so much less expensive than the devastating costs of regret."

"All change is hard at first, messy in the middle and gorgeous at the end."

- Destruction (22 days). Starting a new habit is always tough, as your brain struggles to break old patterns and rewire new ones. Each time you hit a wall, push through it no matter what. Remind yourself that the hardest parts are also the most valuable.
- Installation (22 Days). This phase is akin to being in the middle of a renovation. The old structures have been torn down, and you're about to install the new ones. You're in unfamiliar territory, things feel chaotic and frustrating, and you may be tired after struggling for a few weeks. Resist the urge to return to old habits. Keep persevering.
- Integration (22 Days). At this phase, the new habit starts to feel familiar, and you start to experience the benefits of your new rewiring.
- If you stick to the same routine consistently for at least 66 days, you'll hit the "Automaticity Point". When the alarm goes off at 5am, it's now second nature for you to jump out of bed and start your ritual without exerting willpower. Don't stop there—direct your willpower to start building another new positive habit!



The 20/20/20 Formula



Your willpower is strongest at the start of your day, and weakens as you get tired. So, the first hour of your day (5-6am) is crucial. Sharma calls this your Victory Hour. He recommends splitting this hour into 3 x 20-minute blocks where you focus on building your Mindset, Heartset, Healthset and Soulset.

- Move (0500-0520): Start your day with intense exercise that makes you sweat. This triggers a host of biochemical reactions in your brain and body to put you in an optimal cognitive state.
 - (i) Specifically, intense exercise reduces your cortisol levels, and releases BDNF (brain-derived neurotrophic factor) which repairs brain cells, promotes new brain cell growth, and speeds up neural connections so you'll think faster/better. Exercise also increases your

KEY QUOTES

"Persistency sits at the threshold of mastery."

"For the A-Player, the top of one mountain is the bottom of the next. The installation of one great new habit brings on the outstanding opportunity to begin the next."

"Take excellent care of the front end of the day, and the rest of your day will pretty much take care of itself. Own your morning. Elevate your life."

levels of dopamine (a neurotransmitter) and serotonin (which regulates happiness).

- (ii) Sharma recommends that you use an old-school alarm clock instead of using your phone. Adjust the clock 30 minutes ahead of the actual time, then set your alarm for 5:30 am to give the illusion that you're waking up later.
- (iii) You can even sleep in your workout clothes to make it easier to start your Victory Hour.
- Reflect (0520-0540): Use the next 20 minutes for quiet reflection, meditation, prayer, journaling or planning. This provides focus and "residual wisdom" to guide your day.
 - (i) Be still and give yourself the gift of serenity and quietude. Contemplate your life, how you wish to express your values, and how you wish to grow.
 - (ii) Think of the day ahead of you. Try listing down 5 mini goals that, if accomplished, will make this a great day.
 - (iii) Download your thoughts and feelings in a journal. Don't overthink it; just write down whatever comes to mind—both the good and the bad. Consider what you're grateful for, and release any hurts or resentments that're weighing you down. When you give voice to your repressed emotions, it lightens your burdens and starts the healing process.
- Grow (0540-0600): Use the final 20 minutes to learn and grow. Consider how you can increase your capacity/ impact and become more valuable to your industry and society. Use the time to read a book, listen to podcasts, watch an educational video, or study the lives of successful people.



The 20/20/20 formula is a keystone habit, i.e. a set of behaviors that multiplies other helpful behaviors. You can adjust or tailor it to suit your needs and preferences.

KEY QUOTES

"The real purpose of commerce is not only to make your personal fortune. The true reason to be in the game is to be helpful to society."



Beyond the Victory Hour and 20/20/20 Formula

You can use these strategies, tactics and insights to amplify your productivity for the rest of your day.



For optimal productivity, creativity, health and longevity, you need 5 x 90-minute sleep cycles, or 7.5 hours of quality sleep each night.

- Your evening routine is as important as your morning routine.
 - (i) Finish your last meal by 8pm and turn off all digital devices. Research found that blue light from digital devices can disrupt sleep and impair cognitive functions.
 - (ii) Use the time before bed to connect with loved ones, meditate, take a relaxing bath, or read/listen to educational materials.
 - (iii) Sleep in a cool, dark room without electronic gadgets.



Learn to conserve and manage your willpower supply:

- Recharge yourself throughout the day so you won't be too exhausted to exercise your willpower or make sound decisions.
- Keep your surroundings neat and tidy, since a messy environment creates distractions that deplete your mental capacity.
- Remove unnecessary decisions to prevent decision-fatigue, e.g. wear the same type of clothes daily or have a fixed routine. Keep your mental capacity for truly important decisions.



Use the "Tight Bubble of Total Focus (TBTF)" to protect your mental focus, physical energy, willpower, time and talent. This is a metaphorical bubble to keep out unwanted distractions, negativity and energy-vampires, so you can operate in a space of solitude and creativity similar to the Victory Hour. Carry this bubble with you, and deliberately choose which people, activities or influences you allow into your life.

KEY QUOTES

"To find your best self you must lose your weak self."

★
== Apply the 90/90/1 Rule to focus on real work. For the next 90 days, set aside the first 90 minutes of your workday (after your Victory Hour) to focus on the 1 top project that'll give you the greatest payoff once it's completed.

🕒 Professional athletes routinely push their muscles to breaking point, then rest for 1-2 days during which their bodies can recover and grow new muscles. Likewise, we must alternate between intense work and complete rest/recovery. Push yourself to the max, then take time to play and recuperate.

- After your 90/90/1 session, use the 60/10 Method to alternate between 60-minute bursts of intense work and 10-minute renewal periods. During the 60 minutes, enter a TBTF so you can work productively in a distraction-free zone. Then, recover fully with a quick walk, music, meditation, etc. for 10 minutes before starting the next 60/10 cycle.
- Occasionally, take longer periods to rest or play, e.g. go on a vacation. When paired with periods of intense work, our play/rest time also doubles up as an incubation window for new ideas and insights.

🧘 Schedule a "Second Wind Workout" at the end of your workday, to give yourself a boost of energy and willpower for the evening. You can also consider a 1-hour nature walk for reflection.

🧖 Schedule 2 weekly sessions of 90-minute deep-tissue massages. This is a good way to reduce stress, improve brain performance and general wellness.

🎓 Study for ≥60 minutes daily, e.g. read a book, take an online course or speak with a mentor. Convert your commute time into learning time. Keep raising your standards in all areas of life, e.g. hone your business skills, people skills, and learn to appreciate fine arts and culinary.

🖋 Delegate the tasks that drain you or things you're weak at, so you can focus on the things that you're great at and love to do.

📅 Every Sunday, set aside 30 minutes to design a gameplan for the coming week. In your journal, record the highlights

KEY QUOTES

of your past week (including the key lessons learned and new areas for optimization). Then, list down your commitments for the coming week, schedule the slots for your Victory Hour, 90/90/1 sessions, 60/10 cycles, and second wind workouts, and set aside time for your loved ones and key priorities.



Other Insights for a Splendid Life



We tend to live as if we have all the time in the world, when life is actually fragile and unpredictable. Make each day count—be true to yourself, pay attention to miracles around you, and don't wait to express your inner genius.



Let your joy be your personal GPS: Focus on people, pursuits, and places that make you feel joyful, blissful and alive. Even if your life seems be crumbling around you, know that the setbacks are only temporary. Once you shift your focus, you'll start to notice new options and opportunities that you may have missed.



The more you give to others, the more you receive. The same dollar flows through the economy to benefit many people, whereas hoarding cash stops it from flowing. True wealth is built on generosity, not scarcity:

- Give generously—from tips to donations, love, compliments and positive thoughts—without expecting anything in return.
- Forgive those who've hurt you. Realize that they do so because they're suffering or in pain themselves. When you forgive, you also release the resentment and toxic emotions in you.



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

The book presents many overlapping ideas and success frameworks without specifying how they're interlinked. Examples include: "The 5-3-1 Creed of The Willpower Warrior", "Twin Cycles of Elite Performance", "10 tactics of lifelong genius",

KEY QUOTES

"Nothing works for those who don't do the work."

"Tomorrow is a bonus, not a right."

"The flow of life rewards positive action and punishes hesitation."